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Who Takes Care of Me?

The reset for the woman caring for aging
parents — while holding up everyone else.

You're caring for everyone. Who's caring for you?

You're the one who shows up — the appointments, the meds, the calls, the worry that never clocks out. Maybe you've got your own kids and a job too. You love them. And you're exhausted, guilty for being exhausted, and quietly grieving a parent who's still here.

That's caregiver burnout, and it's real. You are not selfish for needing care too. This is permission — and a plan — to put a little back in your own cup.

THE TRUTH

You cannot pour from an empty cup. Taking care of you isn't taking away from them — it's what lets you keep going.

STEP 1

The caregiver burnout check

Tick what's been true. This isn't weakness — it's the cost of carrying a lot, for a long time.

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| ☐ Exhausted in a way sleep doesn't fix | ☐ Crying in the car / bathroom |
| ☐ Resentful, then guilty for it | ☐ Isolated — no one gets it |
| ☐ Dreading the next call or visit | ☐ Grieving them while they're still here |
| ☐ No time for my own doctor / needs | ☐ Numb or going through the motions |
| ☐ Snapping at the people I love | ☐ "If I stop, it all falls apart" |

Several of these? You're not failing. You're carrying too much, alone. Let's lighten it — starting with the next page.

STEP 2

Put something back in your cup

You won't get a week off. You can get small, real refills — and they add up. Pick a few this week:

- **15 minutes that are yours.** A walk, a coffee, a closed door. Non-negotiable.
- **Book your own appointment.** The one you keep putting off. You count too.
- **Accept the offer.** Next time someone says "let me know" — give them a real task.
- **Protect your sleep.** It's not a luxury; it's how you keep functioning.
- **One thing off your list.** Delegate, simplify, or let it be "good enough."

My 15 minutes today will be:

STEP 3

Share the load (you weren't meant to carry it alone)

The help won't offer itself specifically — you have to assign it. Use these, calmly and clearly:

- “ I need you to take one regular thing. Can you own [Tuesdays / the pharmacy / the bills]?
- “ I can't be the only one doing this. Let's split it — here's the list.
- “ I'm not able to add anything else right now.
- “ Looking into paid help or respite care isn't giving up — it's making this sustainable.

SAY IT PLAINLY

Family often doesn't step up because you make it look manageable. Name the specific job and hand it over.

STEP 4

Caregiver guilt vs the truth

The guilt lies to you constantly. Trade each lie for what's actually true:

THE GUILT

"Resting means I don't care enough."

THE TRUTH

Rest is what keeps me able to care at all.
Burnout helps no one.

THE GUILT

"Getting help is abandoning them."

THE TRUTH

More hands means better care — and a me who isn't breaking.

THE GUILT

"Feeling resentful makes me a bad daughter."

THE TRUTH

Resentment is normal under this much load.
It's a signal to share it, not shame.

You matter too.

Read them on the heavy days. They're true:

- I am a person, not just a caregiver.
- My needs don't disappear because theirs are bigger.
- Asking for help is strength, not failure.
- I can love them deeply and still need a break from caring for them.
- Taking care of me is part of taking care of them.

You don't have to do this alone. Look up your local Area Agency on Aging or a caregiver support line for respite options and someone to talk to. Reaching out is allowed.

You can't pour from an empty cup.

Fifteen minutes. One handed-off task. One appointment kept for you. You are allowed to be cared for too — and the love you give lasts longer when you do.

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